

Teo Mendoza

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Portfolio - teomendoza.github.io

Education

Willamette University
B.S. in Computer Science
GPA: 3.94

Expected Graduation: 2027

Projects

Birthright – 1v1 Online Card Battler

- Designed and developed a competitive 1v1 strategy card game emphasizing tempo, commitment, and reading opponent intent over chance-driven outcomes, built on the principle that every advantage carries a cost.
- Built the game around a low power creep philosophy with card costs capped at 1–5 gold, gold resetting every turn instead of accumulating, and utility scaling with cost instead of raw stats, so no single card or turn can overwhelm the game on its own.
- Layered units, spells, traits, and abilities into a deep toolkit that rewards planning and setup, letting players build advantages ahead of time to outmaneuver opponents and swing momentum in their favor.
- Designed a unit-management layer where every unit commits to attacking, defending, or its own utility each turn, and non-regenerating defense makes keeping key units alive an ongoing strategic investment.
- Implemented a server-authoritative multiplayer architecture in Rust on SpacetimeDB, with a Godot and C# client, to keep both players' game state synchronized in real time, including ability activation and targeting.
- Released the game publicly on itch.io, growing an early playerbase to 30 players and counting through iterative updates and player feedback.

Bash – 3D Multiplayer Shooter

- Designed and developed a fast-paced, free-for-all multiplayer combat game centered on continuous player engagement rather than traditional team-based objectives.
- Created a gameplay loop focused on nonstop engagement, where players quickly re-enter combat, prioritizing action and interaction over slower pacing.
- Designed multiple playable characters with distinct combat identities and full ability kits, emphasizing skill expression through mechanics such as movement disruption, targeted stuns, and sight-based blinds.
- Balanced chaotic multiplayer encounters through skill-based systems such as player mechanics, ability usage, and positioning, maintaining depth and competitive play within a highly dynamic environment.
- Delivered a complete playable product, including UI/UX systems, audio feedback, and map design, ensuring clarity, responsiveness, and overall gameplay feel.
- Implemented a server-authoritative multiplayer architecture with custom physics and collision systems to ensure fair, consistent, and responsive gameplay across all players.

Terminal Fighter – 2D Multiplayer Shooter

- Designed and developed a 1v1 multiplayer combat game focused on skill-based duels, emphasizing direct player competition without external objectives or team dynamics.

- Designed a combat system focused on spacing, timing, and player reads, where responsive movement and ability interactions directly determine outcomes in 1v1 encounters.
- Designed two playable characters with distinct combat identities and ability kits, creating varied playstyles while maintaining balance and clarity in head-to-head encounters.
- Developed a minimal arena to support clear engagements and decision-making, ensuring that outcomes were driven by player skill rather than environmental complexity.
- Implemented LAN-based multiplayer using Godot's networking systems with a custom matchmaking server to enable consistent and responsive 1v1 play.

Murder Mystery – Narrative & Game Design

- Designed a narrative-driven game concept centered on a cult-based mystery, structuring the experience around player discovery, exploration, and layered story reveals.
- Created a cast of 12 interconnected characters with distinct personalities, relationships, and hidden motives, designed to support dynamic interactions and evolving player understanding.
- Developed core gameplay concepts including clue gathering and dialogue-driven progression, using character interactions to reveal information and advance the narrative.
- Defined a cohesive player experience combining narrative tension and consequence-driven progression to guide engagement and pacing.

Work Experience

Pedagogical – Project Manager & Backend Developer

May 2025 – August 2025

- Led a 3 person team developing Pedagogical, an NSF-funded AI-driven education platform deployed across multiple university courses, supporting 150+ students.
- Drove product direction and development by translating research goals into structured system designs, feature roadmaps, and implementation cycles.
- Designed and implemented backend systems for analytics, interaction logging, and AI-driven feedback pipelines, shaping how student behavior is used to guide learning outcomes.

Teaching Assistant – Intro to Game Development in Unity

August 2025 – December 2025

- Supported 25 students during in-class coding demonstrations and project work by clarifying technical concepts, answering questions, and debugging issues in real time.
- Held weekly office hours to assist with debugging, technical problem solving, and feedback on game mechanics and design decisions for individual and group projects.
- Evaluated homework and projects by assessing code quality, technical correctness, and design elements such as mechanic clarity, player engagement, and usability.

Resident Advisor – Willamette University

August 2024 – May 2025

- Supervised a community of 50 residents and collaborated with staff to support a housing population of 600+ students.
- Mediated conflicts, enforced university policies, and responded to crises to maintain a safe and structured living environment.
- Planned and led weekly programs and large-scale monthly events to foster community engagement and student well-being.

Publications

Mendoza, T., et al. (2025). *Not All Chatbots Teach: Evidence for Pedagogical Design in AI-Assisted Technical Education*. ACM SIGCITE 2025.

Skills

Game Design: Combat Systems, Multiplayer Systems, UI/UX, Character & Ability Design

Programming: Rust, C#, SQL, Python, GDScript, Bash

Systems: Multiplayer Networking, Server-Authoritative Architecture, Physics Programming, Database Design

Tools: Unity, Godot, SpacetimeDB, Docker, Git/GitHub, PostgreSQL

Product & Leadership: Agile Development, Product Planning, Technical Project Management

Awards

Murdock Science Research Conference – Best Presentation

2024